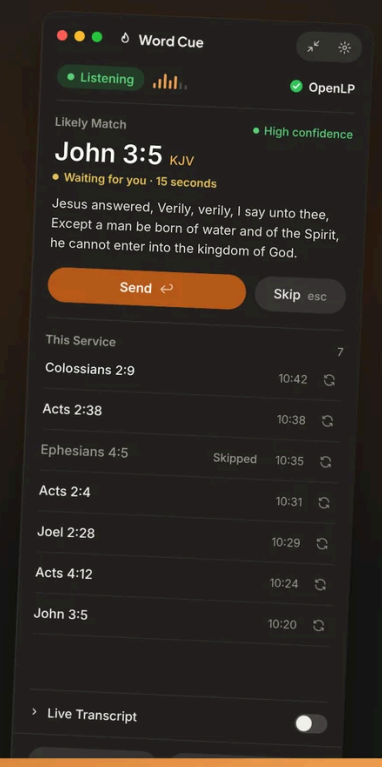
FRESH FIRE STUDIOS

Word Cue

Product Overview & User Guide

"Scripture on screen the moment it's preached."

Version 1.0 · pre-release | macOS 27+ | Apple silicon | Native SwiftUI | Free & open source



01 What Is Word Cue

Word Cue is a native macOS companion app that listens to the pulpit mic through your soundboard, recognizes scripture as it is preached, and lets the booth operator put it on screen in OpenLP with one key. Everything runs on the booth Mac. No internet, no cloud, no recordings.

It covers the two ways scripture reaches the screen on a Sunday:

- **Live detection.** Continuous listening during the sermon. Each verse the preacher reaches appears as a Likely Match, ready to Send or Skip.
- **From files.** Drop the pastor's sermon notes (PDF, image or text) onto Word Cue and every reference goes straight into OpenLP's service list, in order.

WHY · In a live, Spirit-led service the preacher moves fast and rarely follows a script. A booth operator typically needs 7 to 14 seconds to find and show a verse by hand. Word Cue has the reference waiting before the operator could have typed it.

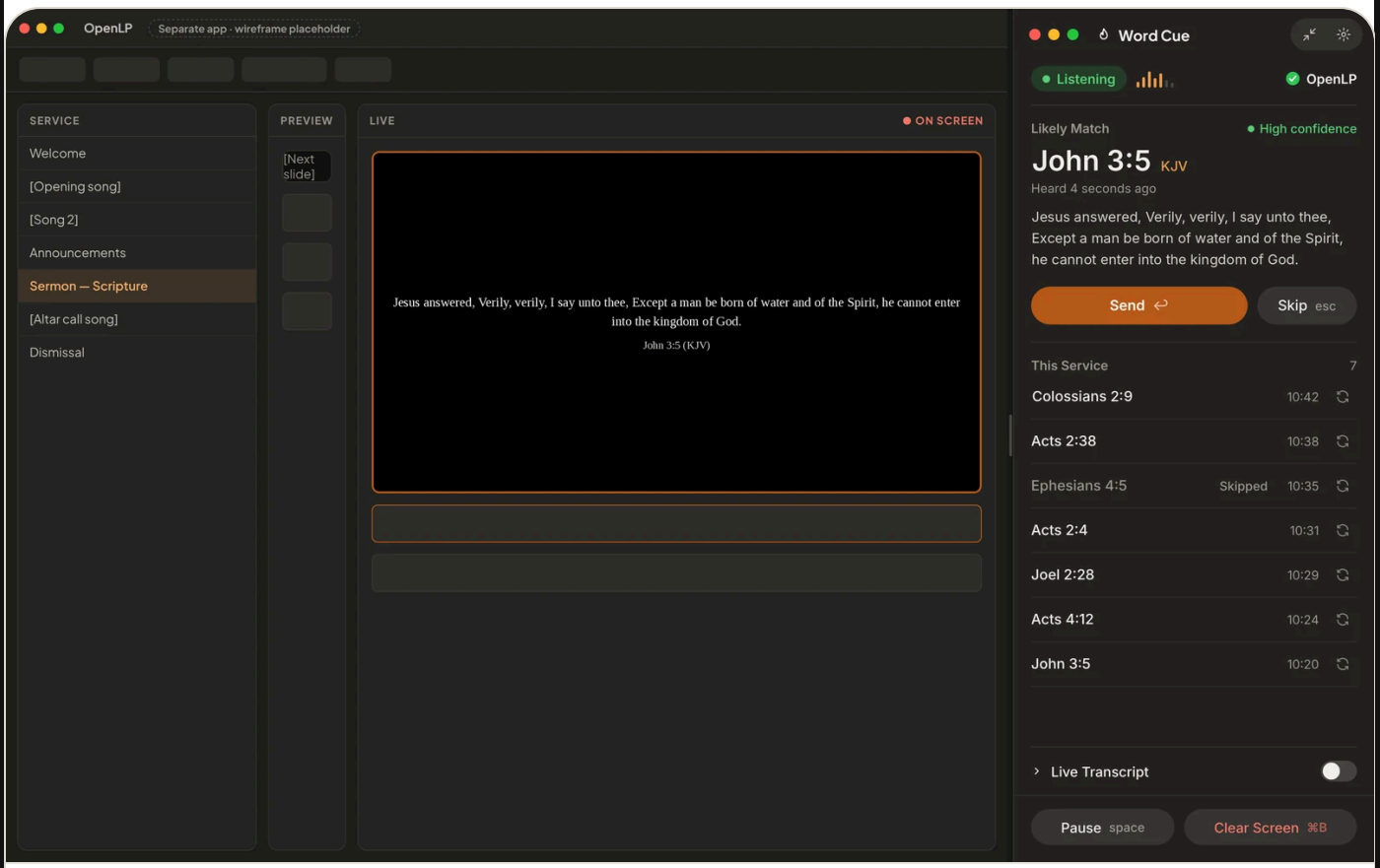


Figure 1 — Word Cue runs as a fixed-width sidebar on the right edge of the operator's screen, beside OpenLP. OpenLP carries the service; Word Cue only cues scripture.

What Word Cue is, and is not

Word Cue is	Word Cue is not
A companion that runs beside OpenLP on the same Mac	A presentation app. Songs, media and slides stay in OpenLP
Listening to the soundboard feed and transcribing on-device	A scripture search tool. Operators search in OpenLP
Suggesting verses that the operator sends or skips	A multi-computer or network system
Private: no cloud, no audio saved	Something that changes the screen on its own by default

Five principles

Every screen and setting is checked against these rules.

1. **Reviewed by default.** Nothing reaches the screen without the operator, unless a church chooses Auto-send.
2. **Private and on-device.** Audio is never recorded or uploaded. Everything runs on the booth Mac.
3. **Apple structure, Fresh Fire identity.** Native macOS layout, controls and type, with Fresh Fire color and wordmark on top.
4. **Stay out of the way.** OpenLP carries the service. Word Cue is a quiet sidebar that never grows into it.
5. **One home per setting.** Every setting lives in exactly one place, with no duplicates across pages or views.

02 First-Run Setup

Setup takes about five minutes and runs once. A five-step window walks the operator through it; the dots at the bottom show progress, and Back is available from step 2 on.

Step 1 — Welcome

Explains the three things Word Cue does: hears the sermon from the soundboard, finds the verses in real time, and waits for the operator to send them.

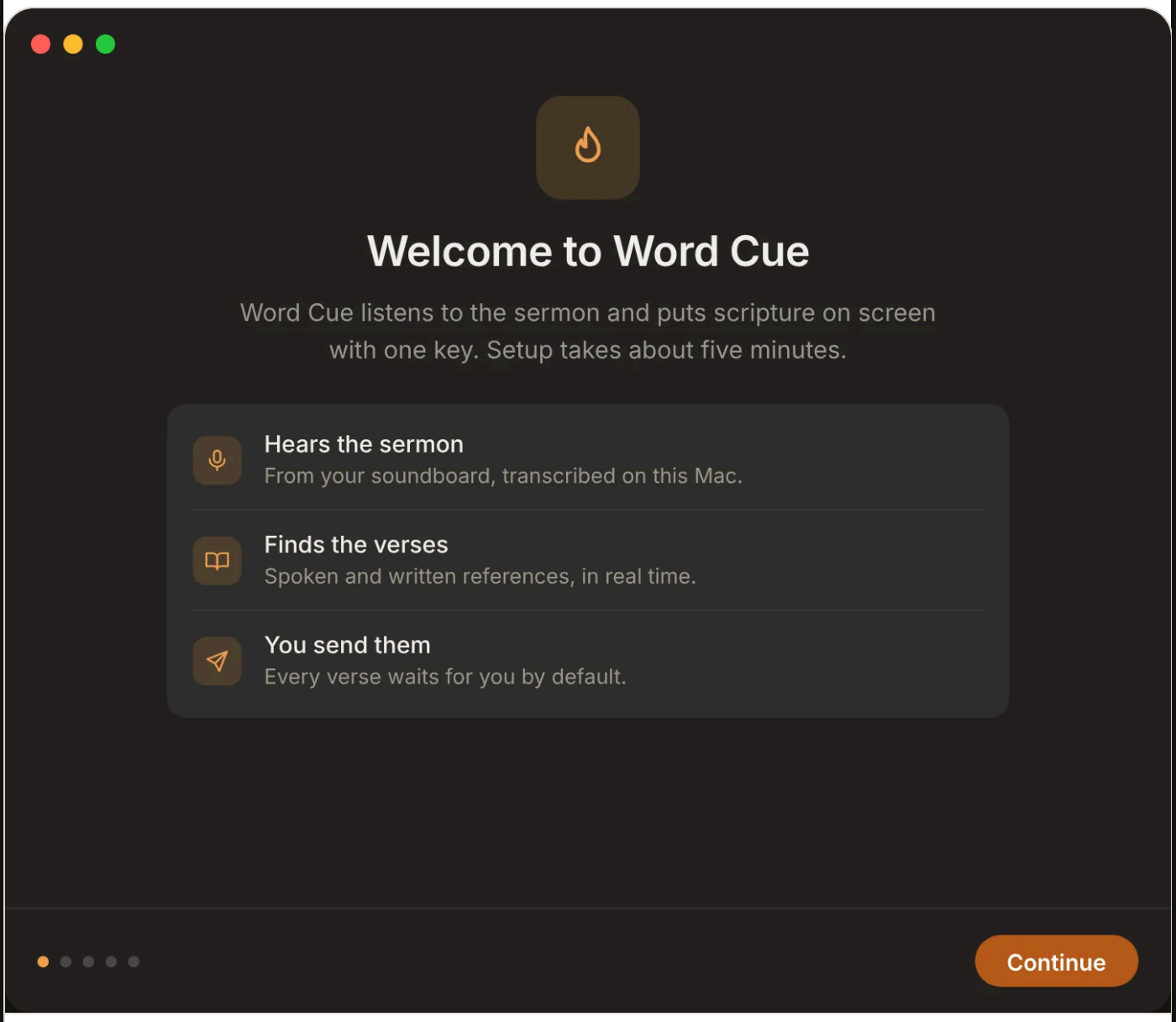


Figure 2 — Welcome screen.

Step 2 — Allow access

Word Cue asks macOS for two permissions: Microphone (to receive audio from the soundboard's USB interface) and Speech Recognition (to transcribe the sermon on this Mac). Accessibility is not requested here; it is asked for later, only if a feature needs it.

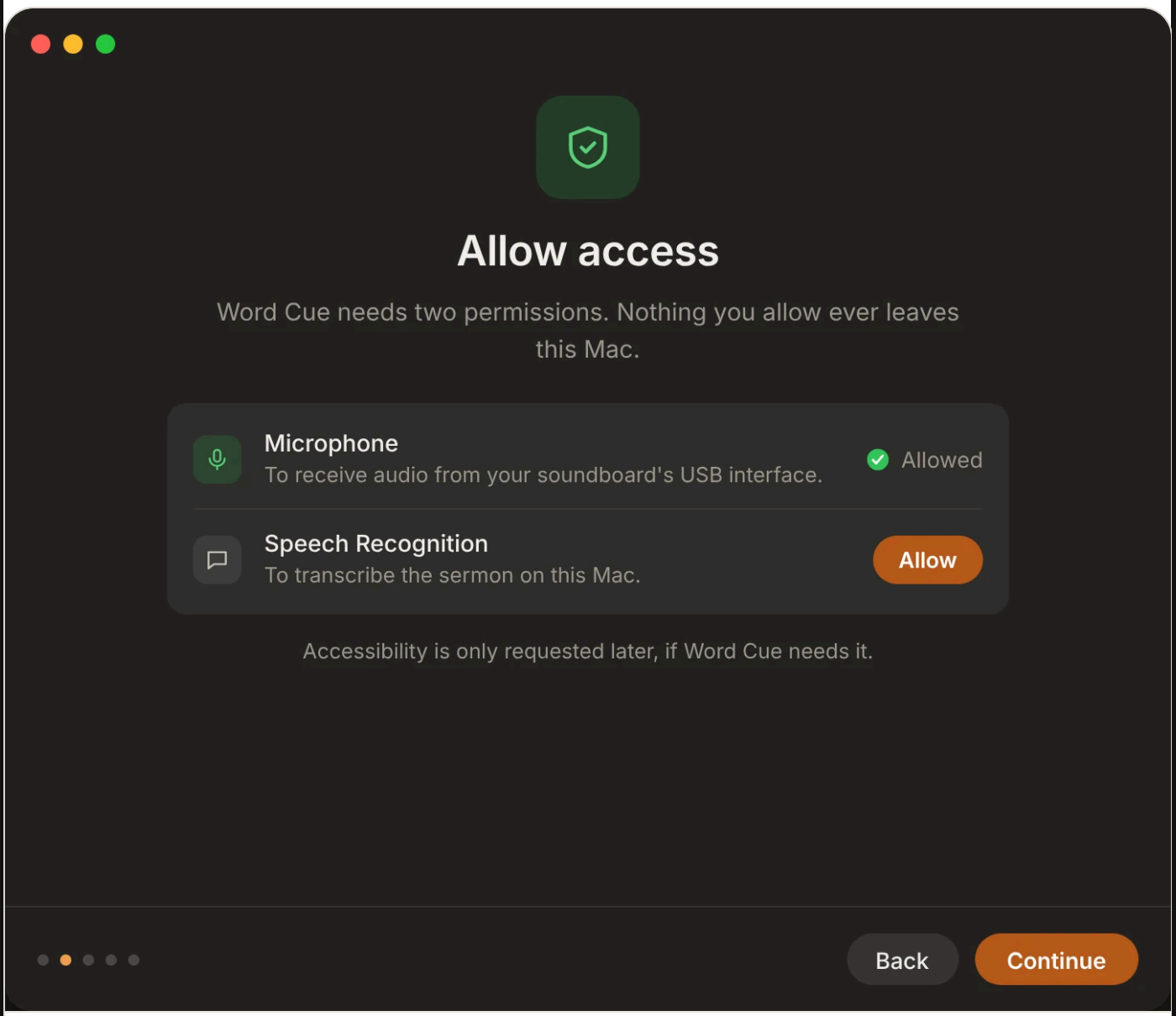


Figure 3 — Permissions. Nothing allowed here ever leaves the Mac.

Step 3 — Choose your audio

Pick the audio interface carrying the soundboard feed and the channel carrying the pulpit mic, then say a few words into it. The live level meter shows a check mark when speech is detected.

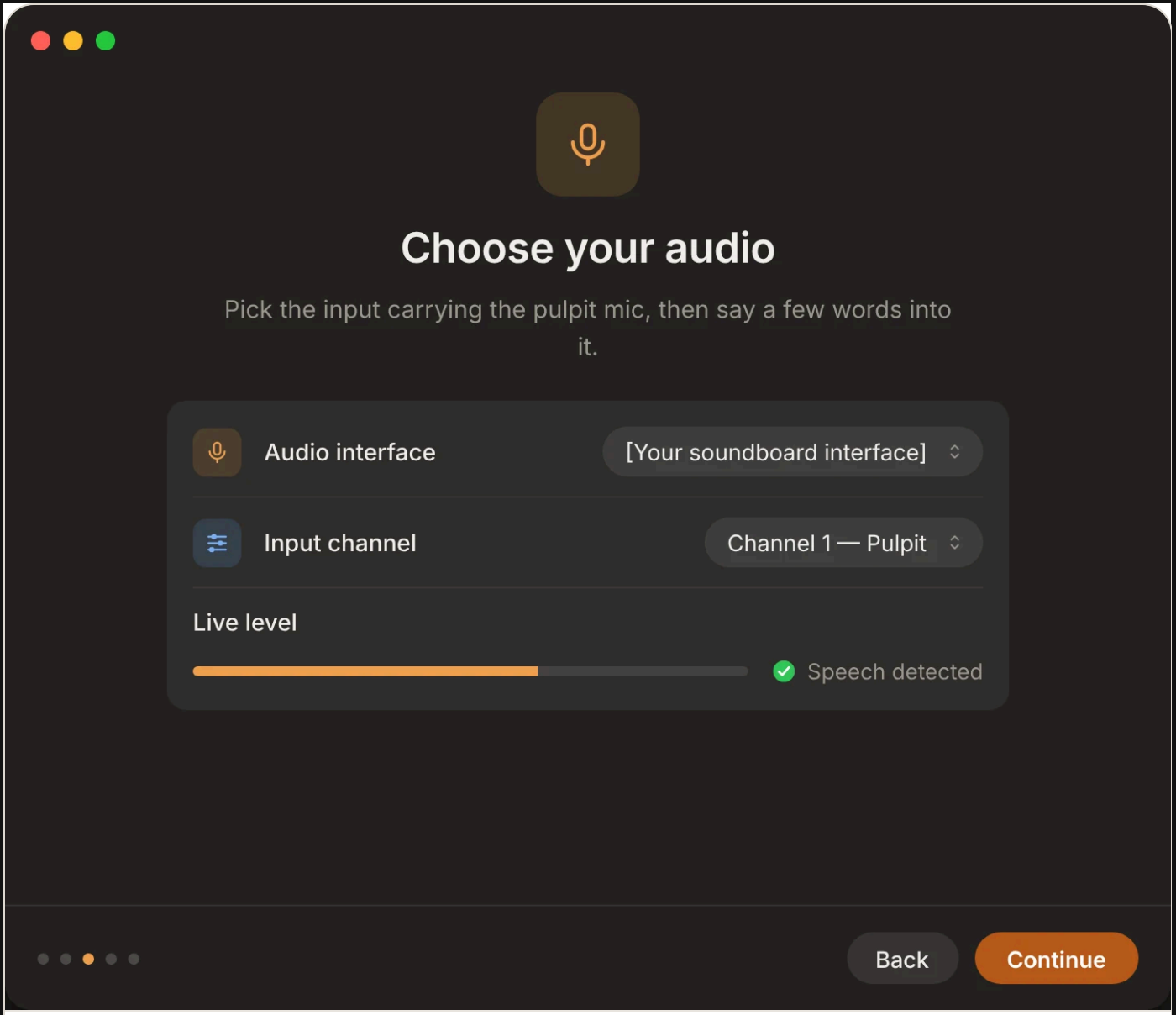


Figure 4 — Audio interface and channel selection with a live level check.

BEST PRACTICE · Feed the pastor's mic channel from the board into a USB audio interface rather than using a room mic. A direct board feed removes room echo, congregation noise and music bleed, which makes transcription far more accurate.

Step 4 — Connect your presentation app

Open OpenLP on the same Mac, turn on Remote in OpenLP's settings, then come back. Word Cue finds OpenLP automatically and shows "Connected to OpenLP · Using OpenLP's API." A Test button sends a signal without changing what is on screen.

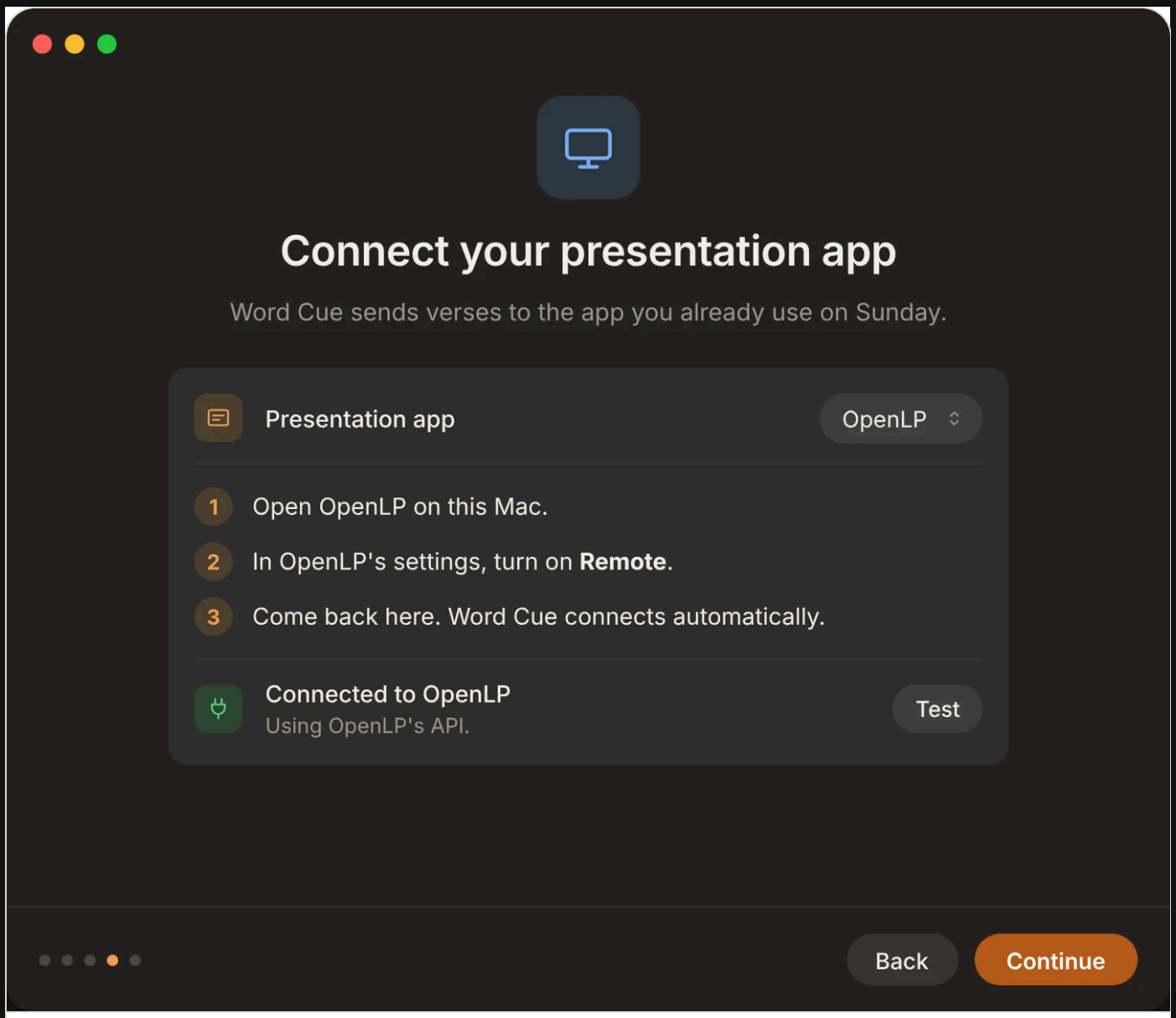


Figure 5 — Connecting to OpenLP.

Step 5 — You're all set

A summary confirms audio, speech recognition and OpenLP are ready. Two switches are on by default: Launch Word Cue at login, and Show Word Cue when OpenLP opens. From now on Word Cue appears beside OpenLP whenever it opens.

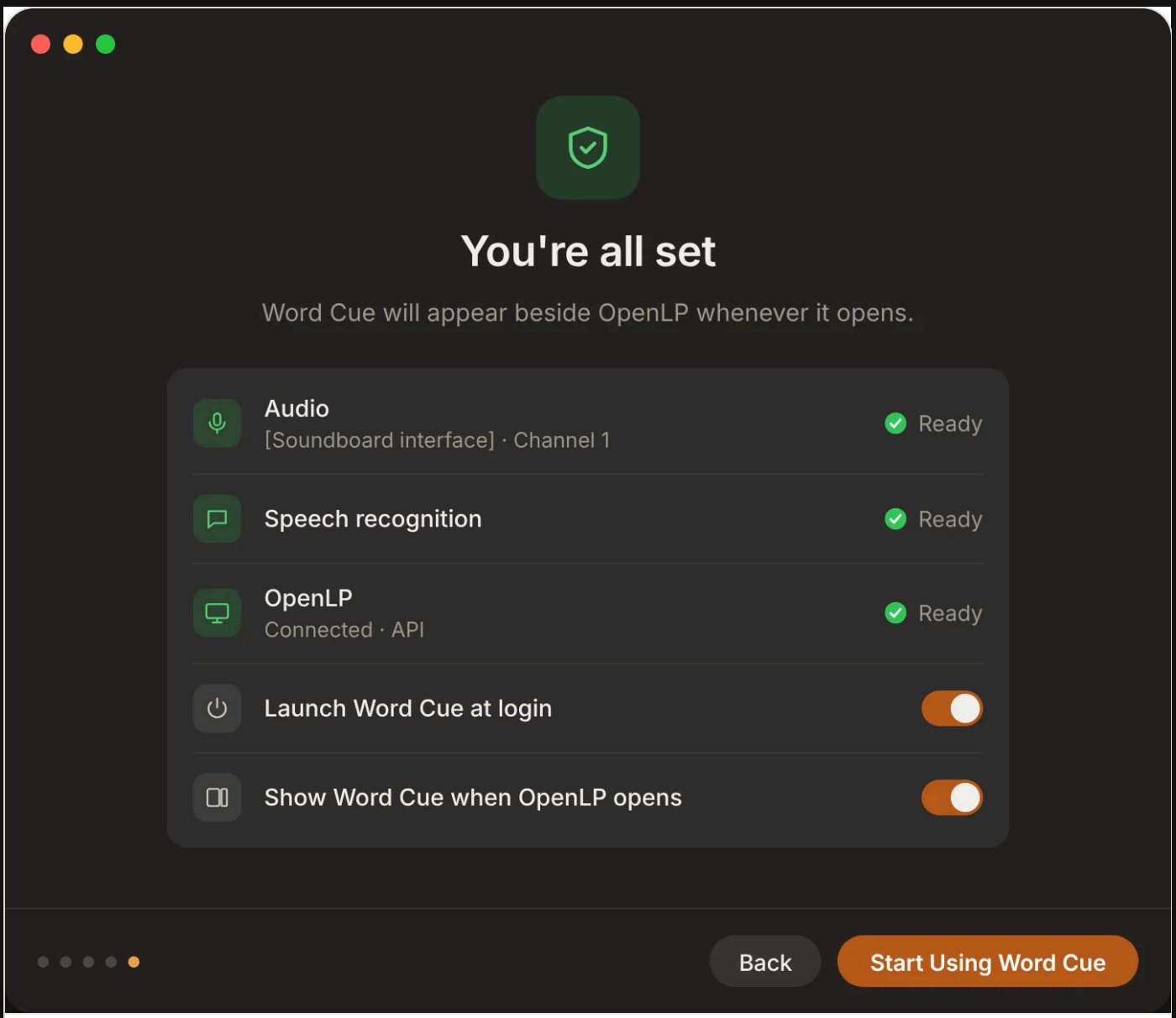


Figure 6 — Setup summary.

03 The Service View

The Service View is where the operator works during a service. It comes in two sizes: a full sidebar (default) and a compact floating panel. Switch between them with the button in the title bar or ⌘.

Full sidebar

A fixed-width sidebar (about 380 px) pinned to the right edge of the operator's screen, full height, never on the projector display. It cannot be dragged wider, so it never grows into OpenLP. Top to bottom:

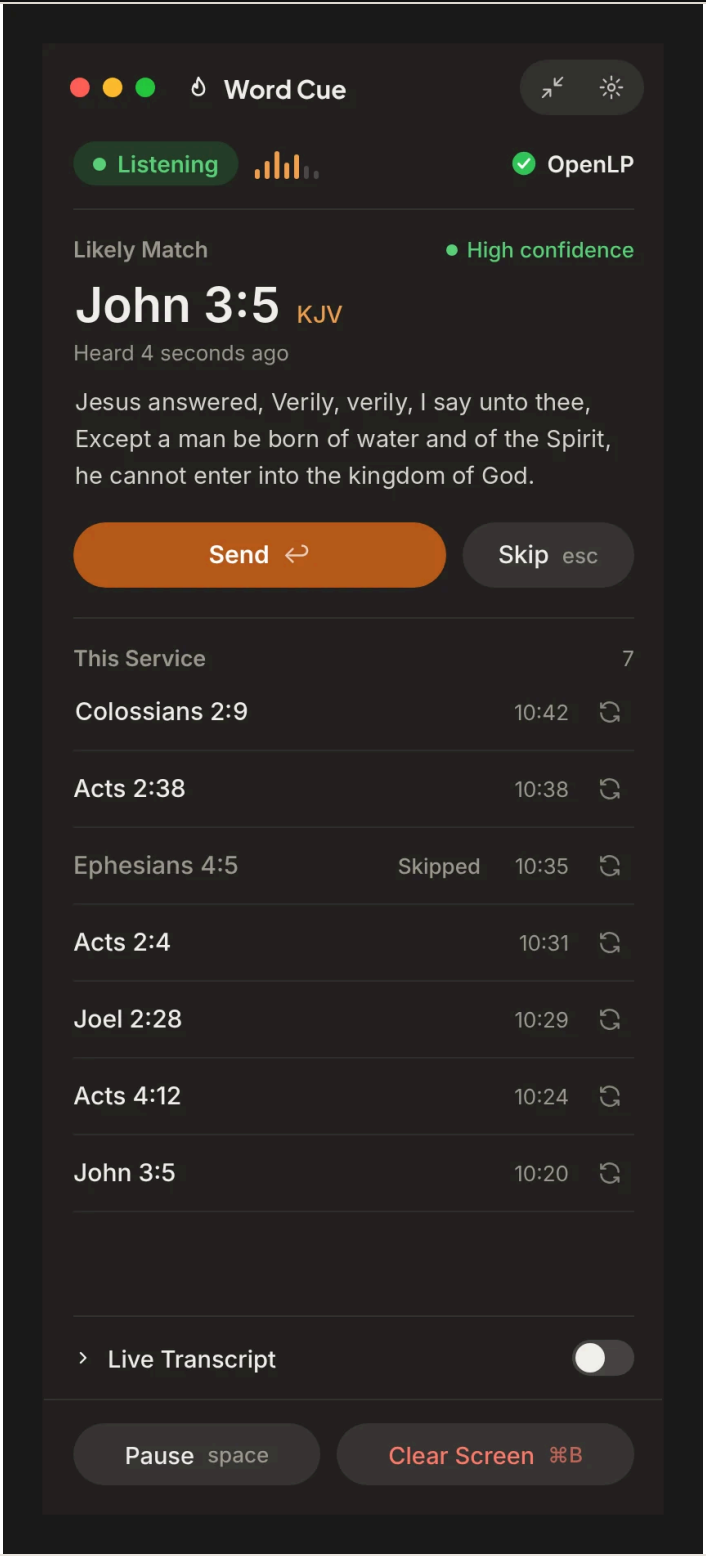


Figure 7 — The full sidebar while listening, with a Likely Match waiting and this service's history below.

Area	What it shows

Title bar	Word Cue wordmark, compact-mode button, Settings button
Status row	Listening / Ready / Paused / No audio pill, a live mic-level meter, and OpenLP's connection status (green check or red ×)
Problem banner	Appears only when something is wrong, with a one-click fix (Reconnect, Audio Settings)
Likely Match	The detected reference in large type (e.g. Acts 2:38), the translation label, a confidence indicator, how long ago it was heard, and the verse text
Send / Skip	Send (↩) puts the verse on screen in OpenLP. Skip (esc) clears it without sending
This Service	Every verse handled this service, newest first, with the time, a Skipped or Auto-sent tag, and a Resend button
Live Transcript	Collapsed and off by default. Turn it on to see the rolling transcript
Footer	Pause / Start Listening (space) and Clear Screen (⌘B)

TIP · Press Return to send and Esc to skip while Word Cue is in front. When OpenLP is in front, the same actions work with ^⌥ added (^⌥↩, ^⌥⎋), so typing in OpenLP is never affected. See section 08.

Compact panel

A small floating panel that stays above other windows, for operators who want OpenLP full-screen with a minimal cue on top. It shows status, the reference with confidence, the first line of the verse, and Send, Skip and Clear Screen. Its corner position, opacity and stay-on-top behavior are set in Appearance.

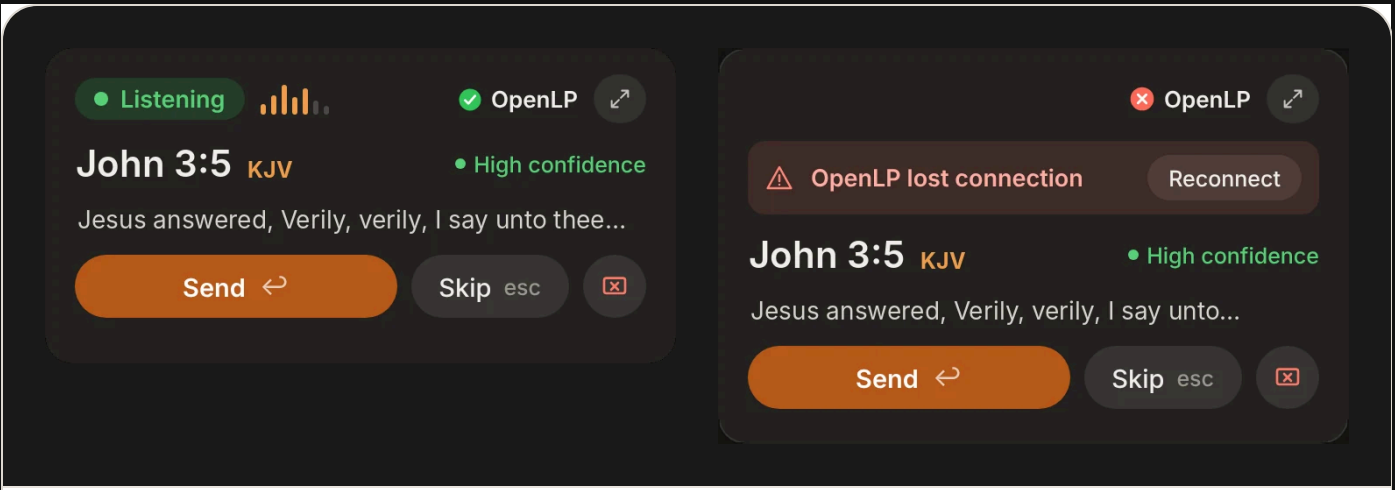


Figure 8 — The compact panel, normal (left) and with OpenLP disconnected (right).

How the windows behave

1. **Mac starts.** Word Cue launches at login and waits quietly in the menu bar.
2. **OpenLP opens.** The sidebar appears on the right edge of the operator's screen.
3. **Operator starts listening.** One click, or automatically when OpenLP opens, depending on the Start listening setting.
4. **A verse is heard.** It appears as a Likely Match. Send or Skip, unless Auto-send is on and confidence is high enough.
5. **Switching apps.** Clicking OpenLP or Word Cue brings both forward; clicking anything else sends both back.
6. **OpenLP quits.** Word Cue hides by default, or quits if the church prefers.

04 Service View States

The sidebar always tells the operator what Word Cue is doing. Status colors each have one job: green is healthy, yellow means a verse is waiting, red means a problem.

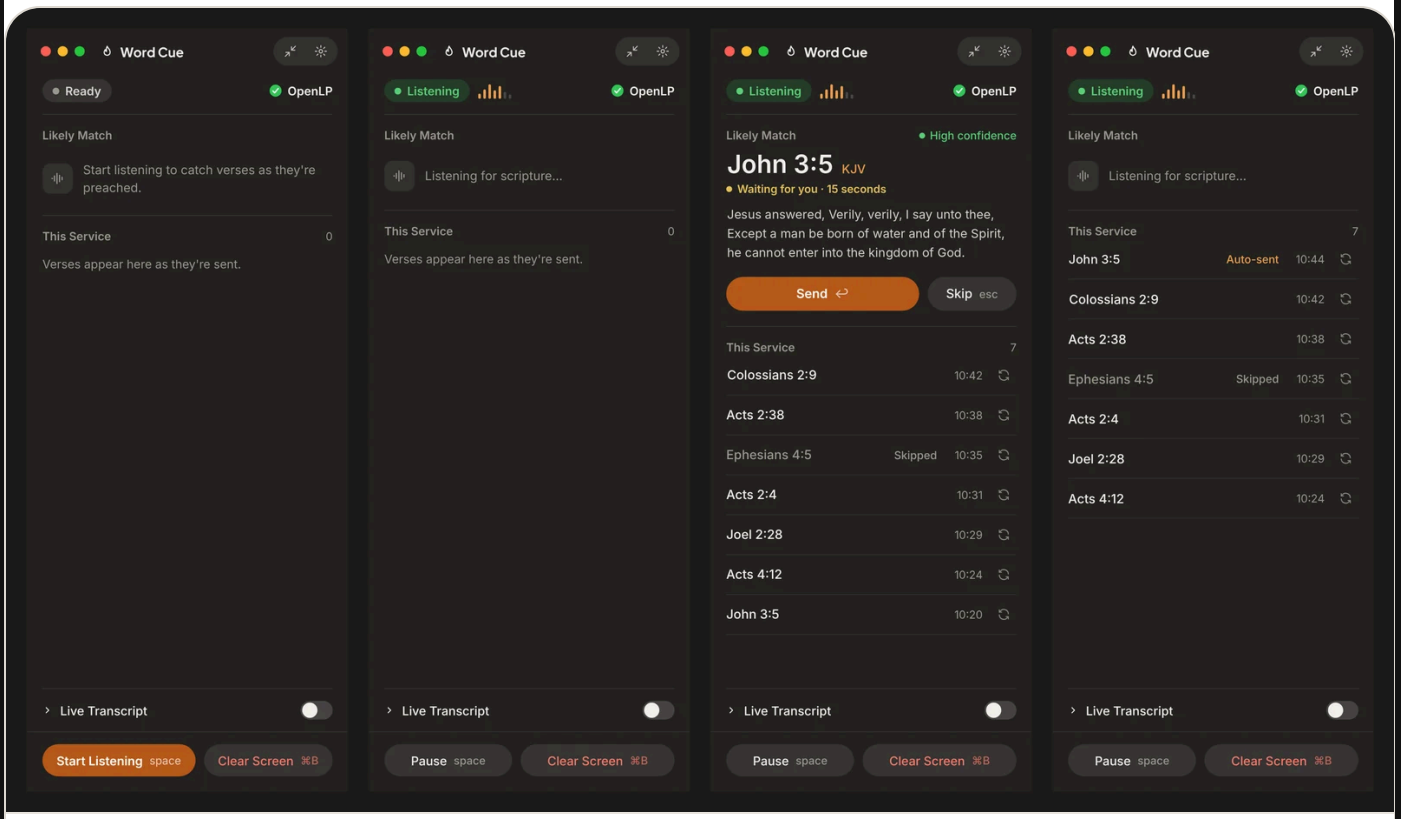


Figure 9 — Normal states, left to right: Ready, Listening with no verses yet, Verse waiting, Auto-sent verse.

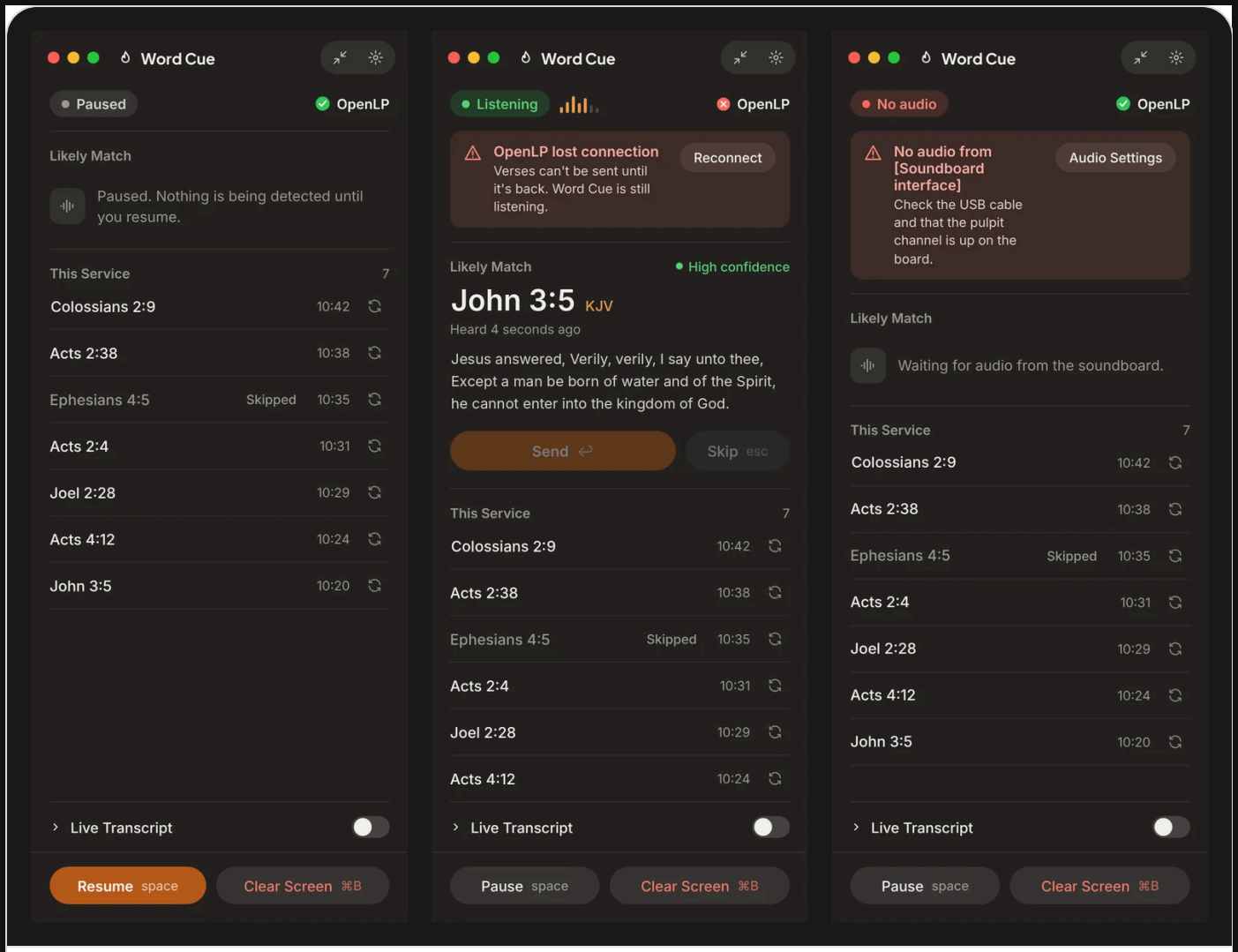


Figure 10 — Paused, OpenLP lost connection, and No audio.

State	Status pill	Likely Match area	Footer button
Ready	Gray "Ready"	"Start listening to catch verses as they're preached."	Start Listening
Listening, no verses yet	Green "Listening" + mic meter	"Listening for scripture…"	Pause
Likely Match	Green "Listening"	Reference, verse text, "Heard 4 seconds ago"	Pause

Verse waiting	Green "Listening"	Yellow "Waiting for you · 15 seconds"	Pause
Auto-sent	Green "Listening"	Back to listening; the verse shows in history tagged Auto-sent	Pause
Paused	Gray "Paused"	"Nothing is being detected until you resume."	Resume
OpenLP lost connection	Green "Listening"; red × by OpenLP	Red banner with Reconnect; Send and Skip dimmed	Pause
No audio	Red "No audio"	Red banner with Audio Settings; "Waiting for audio from the soundboard."	Pause

In the OpenLP-lost state Word Cue keeps listening, so nothing is missed. Detected verses stay in the history and can be resent once OpenLP is back.

05 Adding Verses From Files

Drag the pastor's sermon notes onto the sidebar and Word Cue loads every reference into OpenLP's service list, in the order they appear. This works before the service or mid-service, and it does not need the microphone at all.

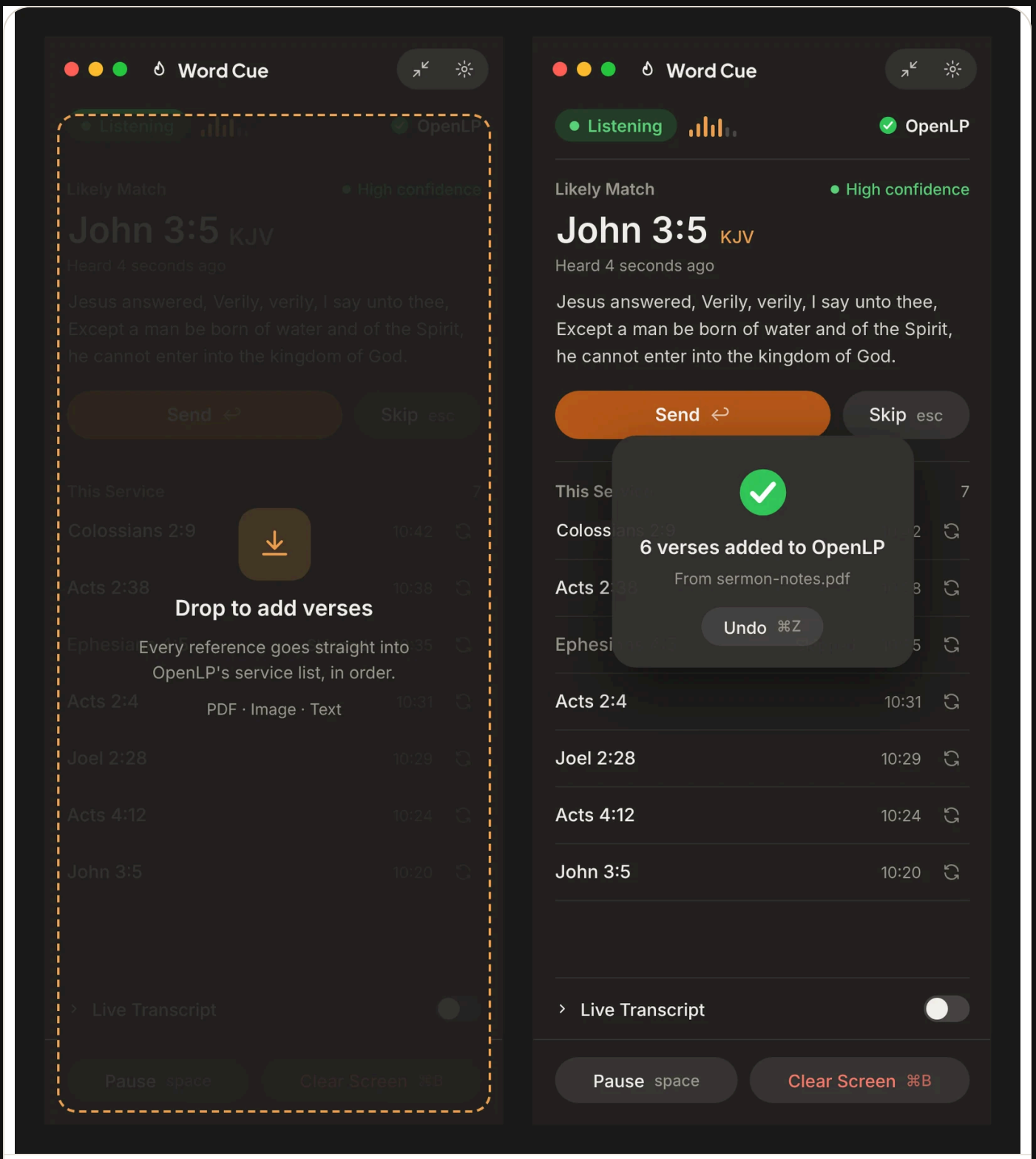


Figure 11 — Dragging a file over the sidebar (left) and the confirmation after the drop (right).

How it works

1. Drag a PDF, image or text file over the Word Cue sidebar. An orange drop zone appears: "Drop to add verses."
2. Drop it. Word Cue reads the file (images through on-device text recognition) and pulls out every scripture reference.
3. The references are added to OpenLP's service list in order. A confirmation shows the count and the file, e.g. "6 verses added to OpenLP · From sermon-notes.pdf."
4. Changed your mind? Press Undo (⌘Z) on the confirmation.

Feature	Detail
Input formats	PDF, image, plain text
Order	Same order the references appear in the file
Destination	OpenLP's service list
Undo	⌘Z from the confirmation
Needs audio?	No. A prepared list works with live listening off

WHY · With the planned scriptures already in OpenLP, live detection becomes the safety net for what wasn't planned rather than the thing the service depends on.

06 How Detection Works

Every verse goes through the same six stages, all on the booth Mac. A human tap sits between detection and the screen unless the church turns on Auto-send.

1. **Listen.** AVAudioEngine reads the chosen USB interface and channel. Apple's on-device Speech framework turns the sermon into text in real time. Standard works on every supported Mac; Enhanced uses Apple Intelligence where available.
2. **Understand.** Apple's on-device Foundation Model reads the transcript and decides whether a scripture reference just happened, and which one. It handles spoken addresses ("turn to Acts 2"), ordinals ("First Timothy"), and verse text quoted without a reference.
3. **Check.** The result is cleaned and verified. "first timothy three sixteen" becomes 1 Timothy 3:16. The book and chapter are confirmed to exist, known recognizer mistakes on KJV names are corrected, and quoted text is looked up in the bundled KJV.
4. **Filter.** Anything below the minimum confidence (70% by default) is dropped. Common-word book names need a chapter number, ignored phrases and books are skipped, and the same verse won't repeat within 60 seconds.
5. **Suggest.** The verse appears as the Likely Match with a confidence indicator. In Review first mode it waits for Send; in Auto-send mode, verses at or above 95% go straight to the screen.
6. **Send.** On approval, Word Cue tells OpenLP to show the verse through OpenLP's remote API, falling back to keyboard shortcuts automatically if the API isn't available.

What Word Cue recognizes

Pattern	Example
Written-style references	"John 3:5"
Spoken references	"John chapter three, verse five"
Verse ranges	"verses five through seven"
Follow-up verses	"…and verse eight" (uses the last chapter mentioned)
Book name variations	"First Timothy," "1st Timothy," "Song of Songs"

Quoted scripture, no reference (Beta)	Spoken verse text matched to the Bible when no reference is said

Avoiding false matches

Several book names are everyday words: Mark, Job, Acts, Numbers, Judges, Revelation, Lamentations. Word Cue only treats them as books when a chapter number follows, so "mark my words" or "acts of kindness" never trigger a verse. Pause detection during music (on by default) keeps worship lyrics that quote scripture from triggering.

BEST PRACTICE · Before the first Sunday, use Run a Practice Session (General › Quick Links) with a recorded sermon. It shows exactly what Word Cue catches and lets you tune the confidence settings without a live service.

07 Settings

Most settings are set once during setup and never touched again. The Settings window has a searchable sidebar with nine pages in three groups: Service (Audio Input, Scripture Detection, Verse Output), Customization (Appearance, Shortcuts & Controls, Filters) and System (Advanced, Support), plus General at the top.

General

The home page: Word Cue's status with a Start Listening button, Cue mode, startup behavior, and quick links.

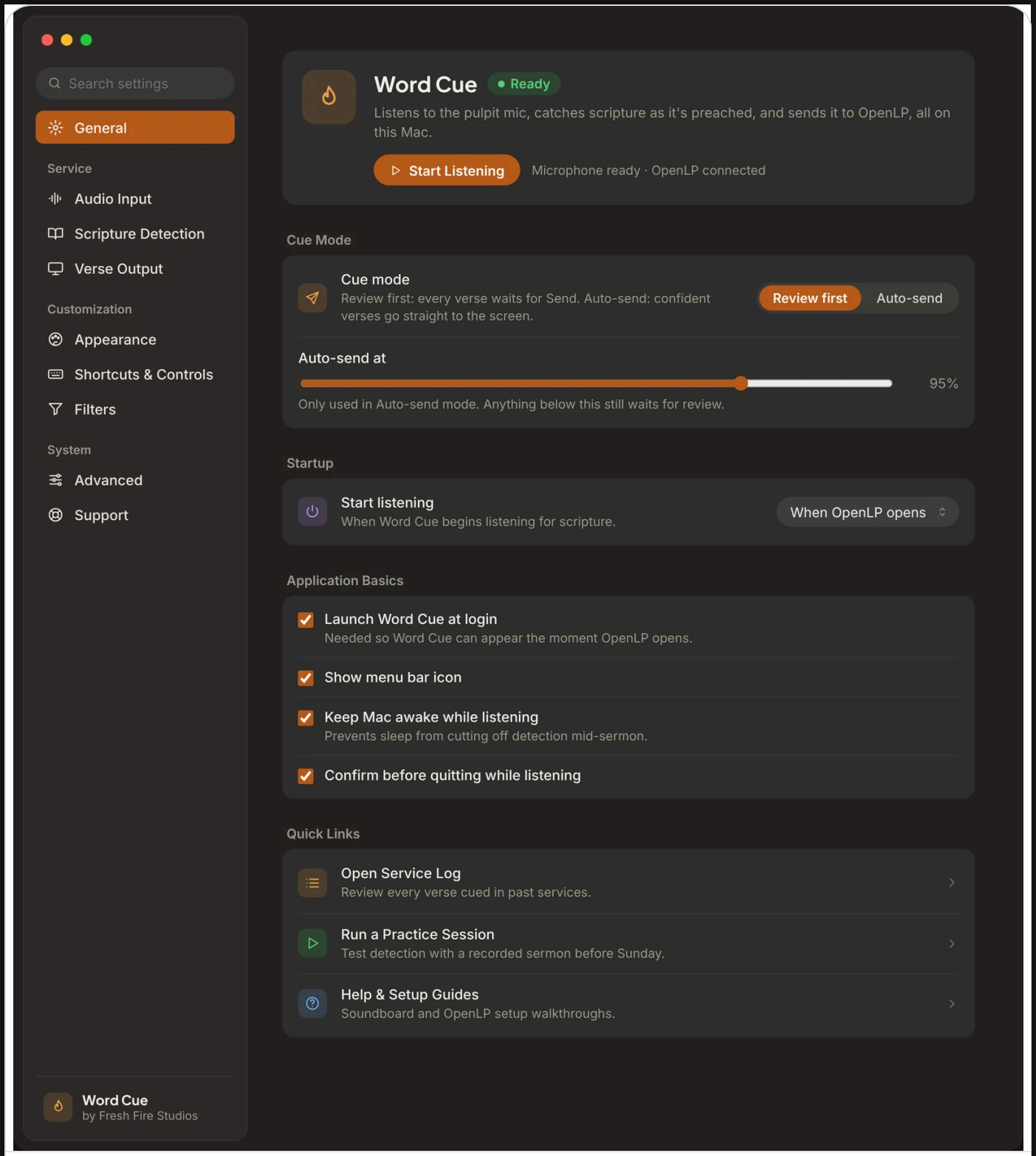


Figure 12 — General settings, with the full Settings sidebar on the left.

Setting	Options	Default

Cue mode	Review first · Auto-send	Review first
Auto-send at	80–100% (Auto-send mode only)	95%
Start listening	When OpenLP opens · Manually	When OpenLP opens
Launch Word Cue at login	On · Off	On
Show menu bar icon	On · Off	On
Keep Mac awake while listening	On · Off	On
Confirm before quitting while listening	On · Off	On

Quick Links open the Service Log, Run a Practice Session, and Help & Setup Guides.

Audio Input

Where the sermon comes from and how it is transcribed. A live meter at the top shows the input, level and whether speech is detected.

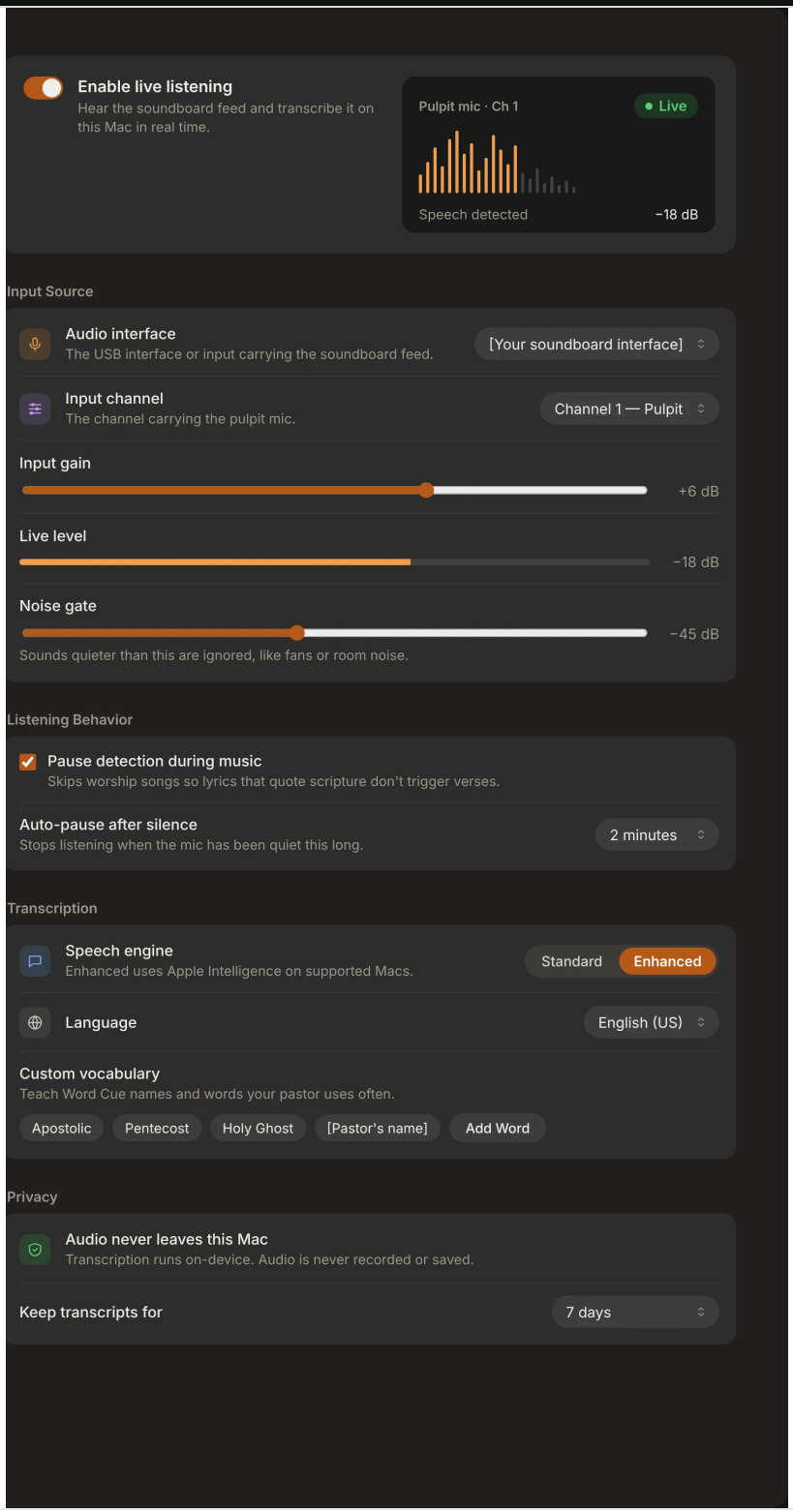


Figure 13 — Audio Input.

Setting	What it does

Audio interface	The USB interface or input carrying the soundboard feed
Input channel	The channel carrying the pulpit mic (e.g. Channel 1 — Pulpit, or Stereo mix 1–2)
Input gain	Boosts a quiet feed; the live level meter shows the result
Noise gate	Sounds quieter than this (fans, room noise) are ignored
Pause detection during music	Skips worship songs so lyrics that quote scripture don't trigger verses
Auto-pause after silence	2, 5 or 10 minutes, or Never
Speech engine	Standard · Enhanced (Apple Intelligence on supported Macs; default)
Language	English (US), Spanish
Custom vocabulary	Words your pastor uses often, e.g. Apostolic, Pentecost, Holy Ghost, the pastor's name
Keep transcripts for	This service only, 7 days (default), 30 days, or Don't keep

Scripture Detection

Which Bible to use, which kinds of references to catch, and how sure Word Cue must be. A preview at the top shows a sample transcript turning into a Likely Match.

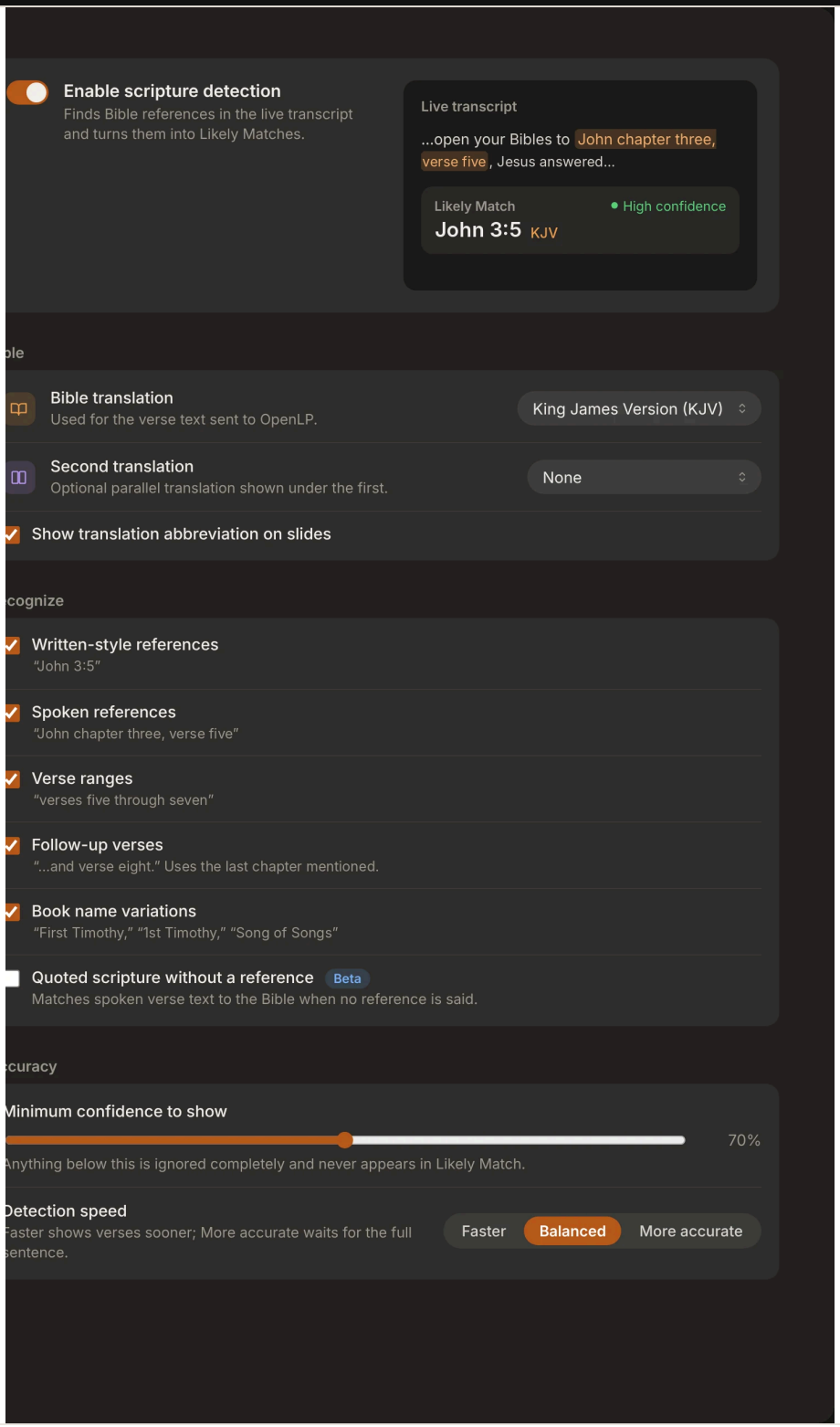


Figure 14 — Scripture Detection.

Setting	Options	Default

Bible translation	KJV · NKJV · ESV	KJV
Second translation	None or a parallel translation shown under the first	None
Show translation abbreviation on slides	On · Off	On
Recognize	The six patterns in section 06, each switchable	All on, except quoted scripture (Beta)
Minimum confidence to show	Slider; anything below is never shown	70%
Detection speed	Faster · Balanced · More accurate	Balanced

Verse Output

How Word Cue talks to OpenLP and how verses land on screen.

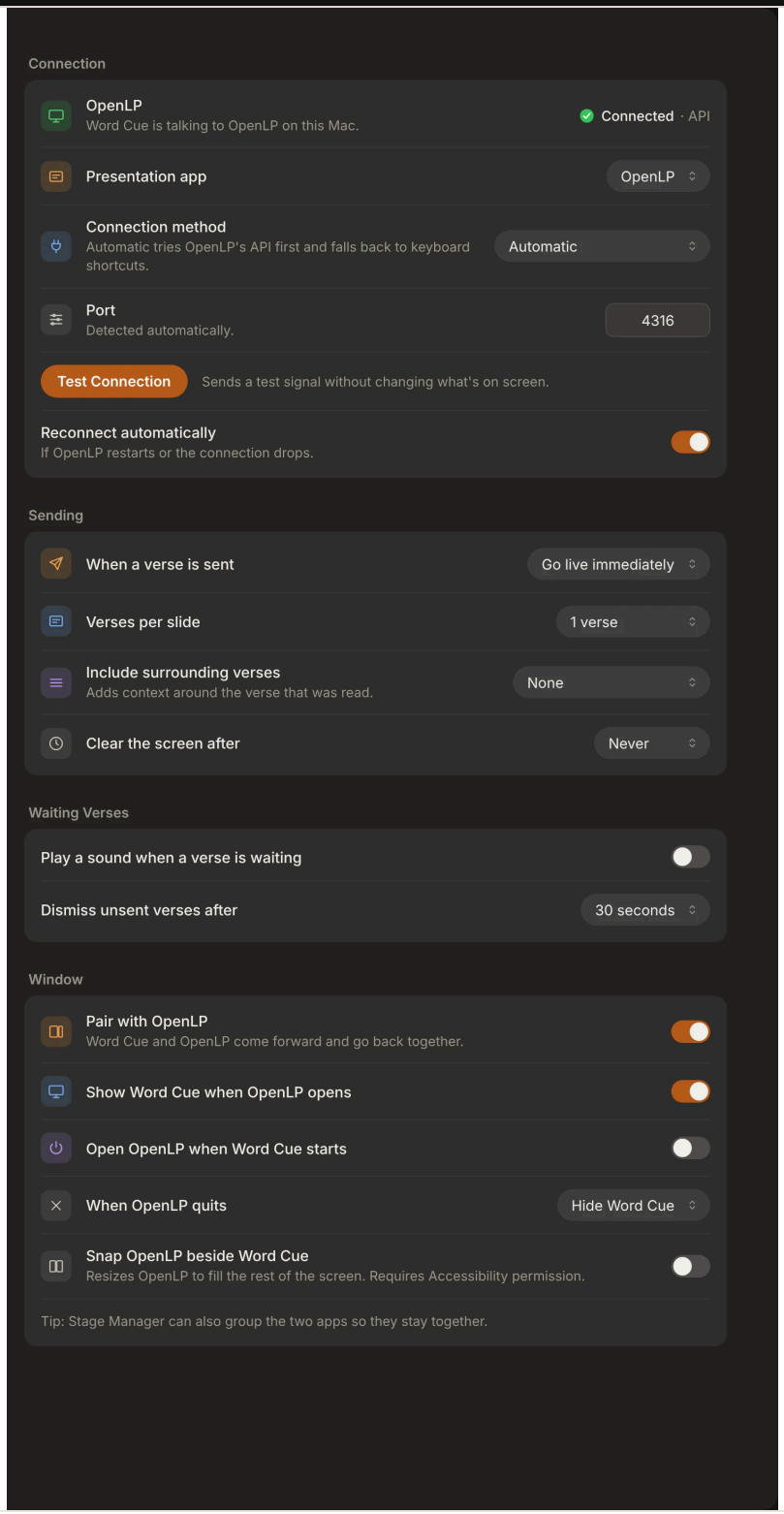


Figure 15 — Verse Output.

Setting	Options	Default

Presentation app	OpenLP	OpenLP
Connection method	Automatic (API first, then keyboard shortcuts) · API only · Keyboard shortcuts only	Automatic
Port	Detected automatically	4316
Reconnect automatically	On · Off	On
When a verse is sent	Go live immediately · Add to service list	Go live immediately
Verses per slide	1 verse · 2 verses · Whole passage	1 verse
Include surrounding verses	None · 1 before and after · Rest of the paragraph	None
Clear the screen after	Never · 1, 2 or 5 minutes	Never
Play a sound when a verse is waiting	On · Off	Off
Dismiss unsent verses after	30 seconds · 1 minute · Never	30 seconds
Pair with OpenLP	Both apps come forward and go back together	On
Show Word Cue when OpenLP opens	On · Off	On
Open OpenLP when Word Cue starts	On · Off	Off
When OpenLP quits	Hide Word Cue · Quit Word Cue	Hide Word Cue

Snap OpenLP beside Word Cue	Resizes OpenLP to fill the rest of the screen; needs Accessibility	Off

Test Connection sends a test signal without changing what's on screen.

TIP · macOS Stage Manager can also group Word Cue and OpenLP so they stay together.

Appearance

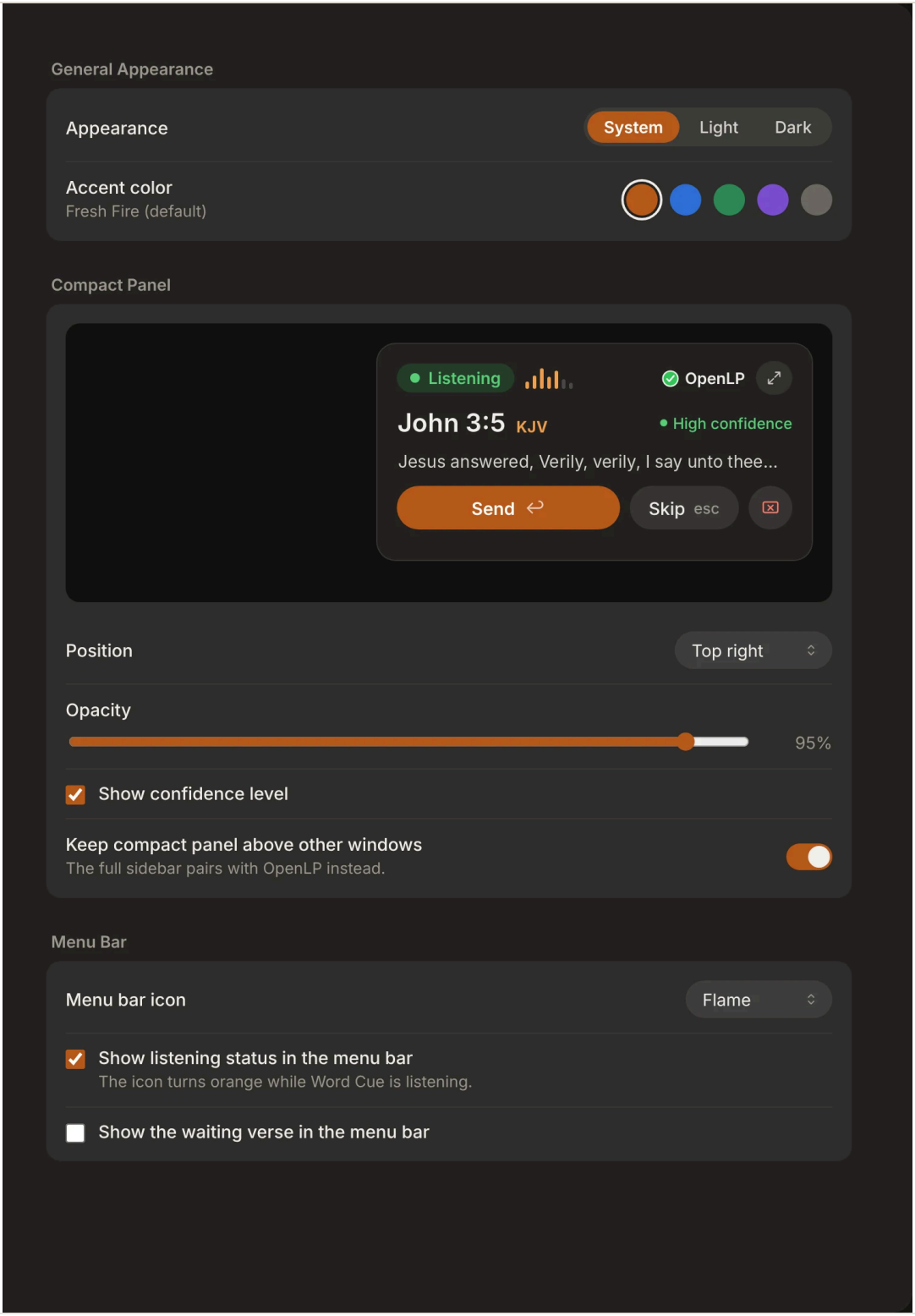


Figure 16 — Appearance, with a live preview of the compact panel.

Setting	Options	Default
Appearance	System · Light · Dark	System
Accent color	Color swatches	Fresh Fire
Compact panel position	Top right · Top left · Bottom right · Bottom left	Top right
Compact panel opacity	Slider	95%
Show confidence level	On · Off	On
Keep compact panel above other windows	On · Off	On
Menu bar icon	Flame · Waveform · Open book	Flame
Show listening status in the menu bar	Icon turns orange while listening	On
Show the waiting verse in the menu bar	On · Off	Off

Shortcuts & Controls

Every service action has an in-app key and an "anywhere" key. The full list is in section 08.

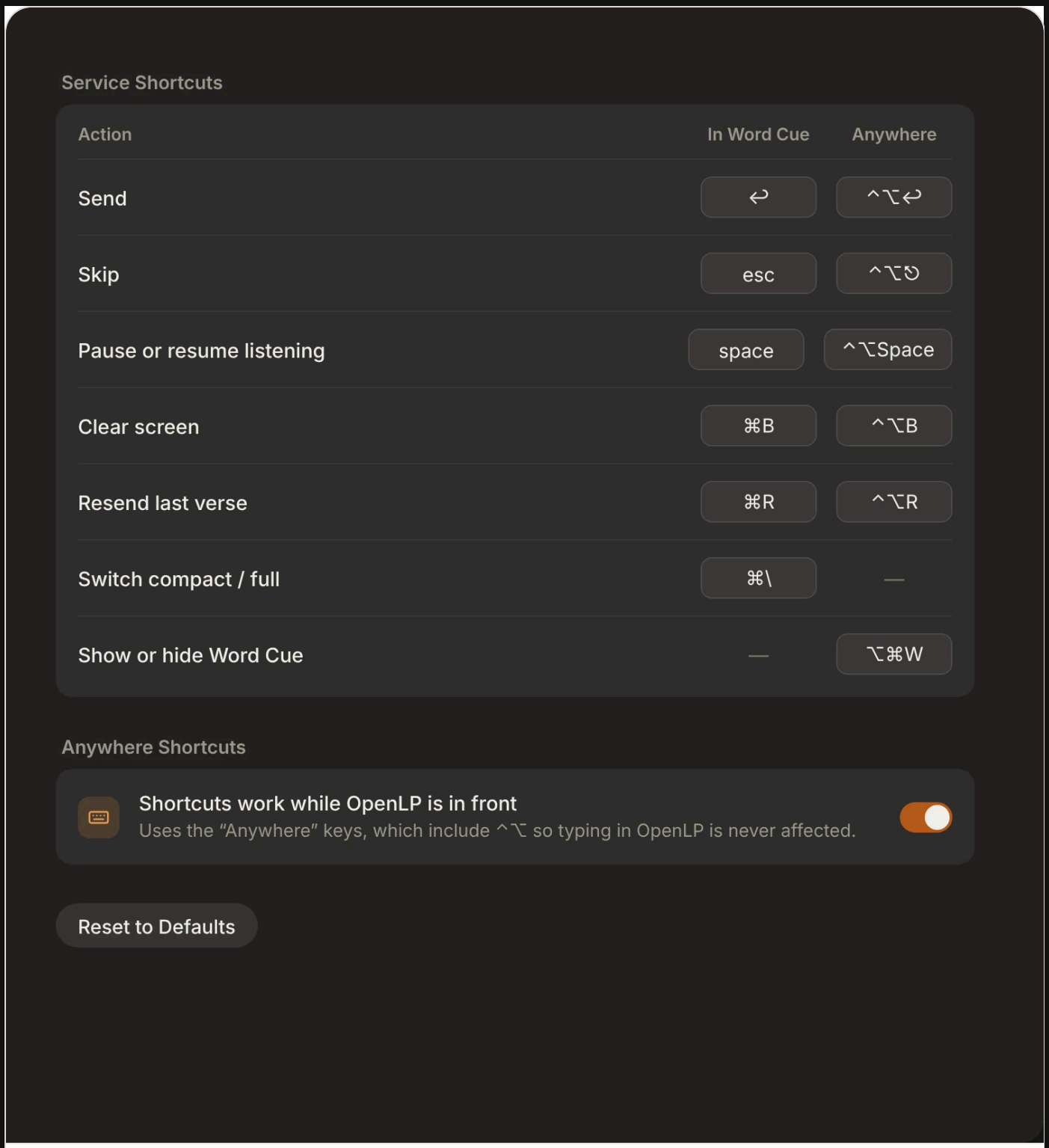


Figure 17 — Shortcuts & Controls.

Filters

Stops everyday speech from turning into verses.

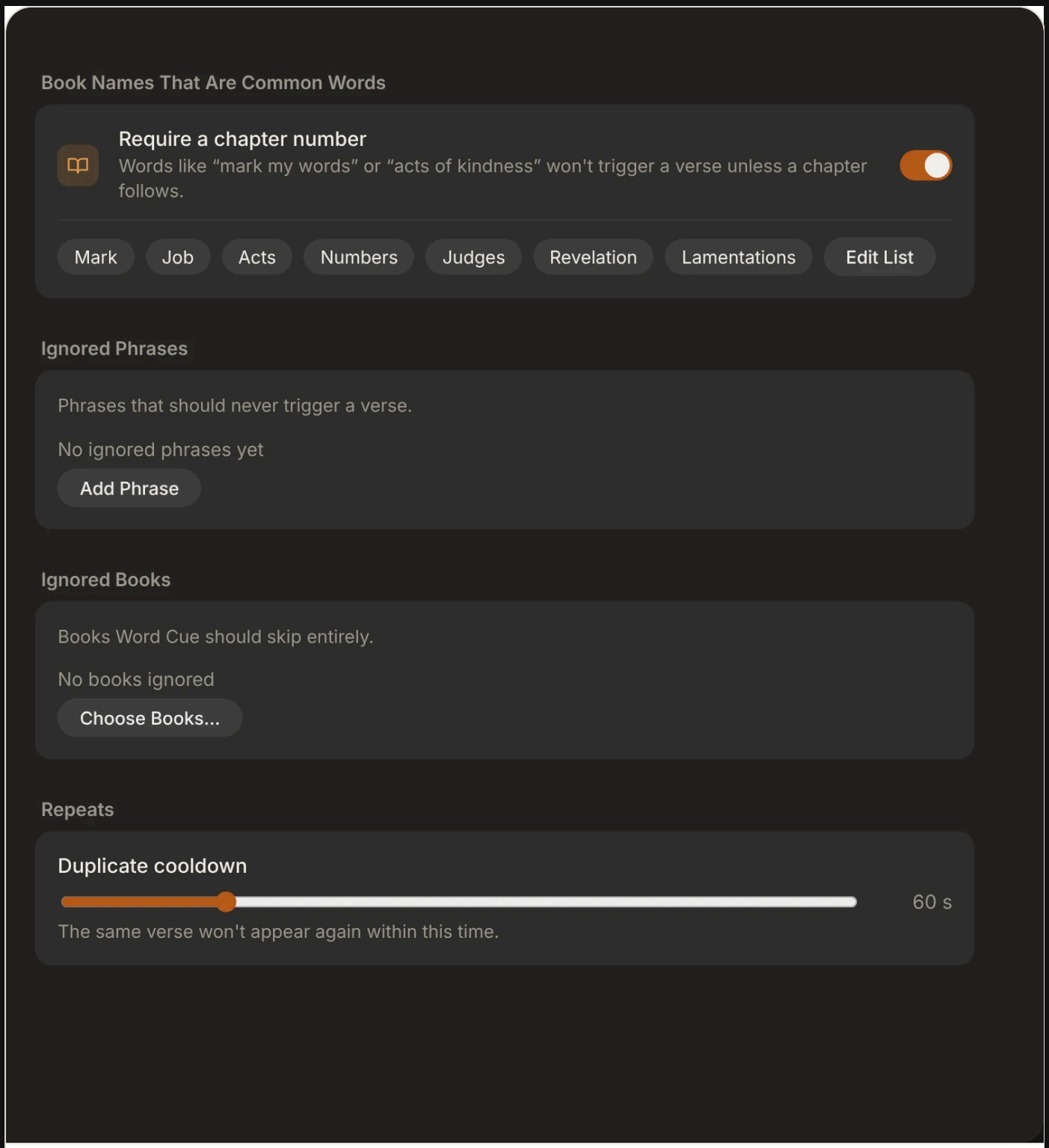


Figure 18 — Filters.

Setting	What it does	Default

Require a chapter number	Common-word books (Mark, Job, Acts, Numbers, Judges, Revelation, Lamentations) only match when a chapter follows; the list is editable	On
Ignored phrases	Phrases that should never trigger a verse	None
Ignored books	Books Word Cue skips entirely	None
Duplicate cooldown	The same verse won't appear again within this time	60 s

Advanced

For troubleshooting and unusual setups. Most churches never open this page.

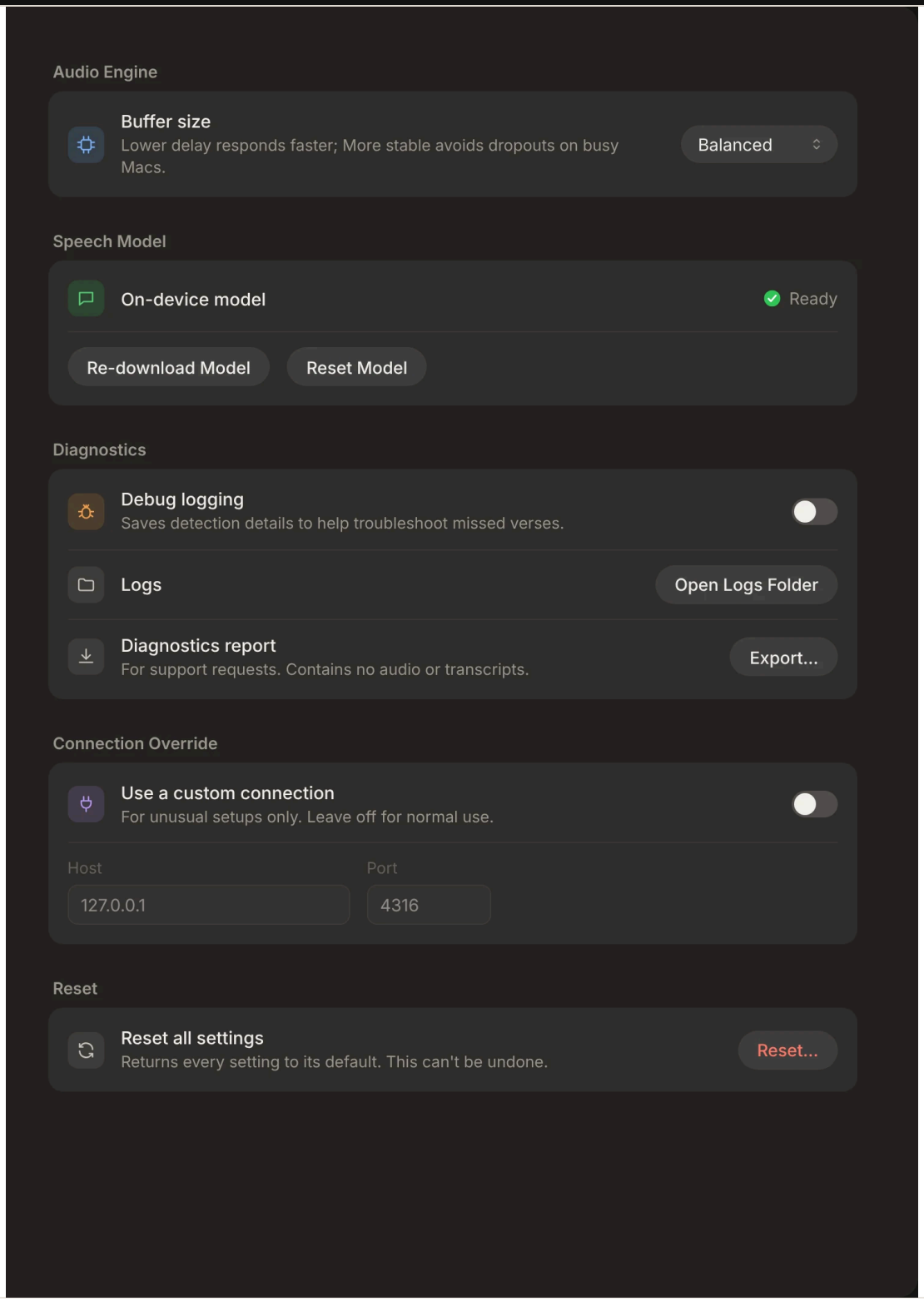


Figure 19 — Advanced.

Setting	What it does

Buffer size	Balanced · Lower delay (faster) · More stable (avoids dropouts on busy Macs)
On-device model	Shows model status; Re-download or Reset the model
Debug logging	Saves detection details to troubleshoot missed verses; Open Logs Folder
Diagnostics report	Export for support requests. Contains no audio or transcripts
Connection override	Custom host and port, for unusual setups only
Reset all settings	Returns every setting to its default. Can't be undone

Support

Contact, permissions, feedback, updates and backup in one place.

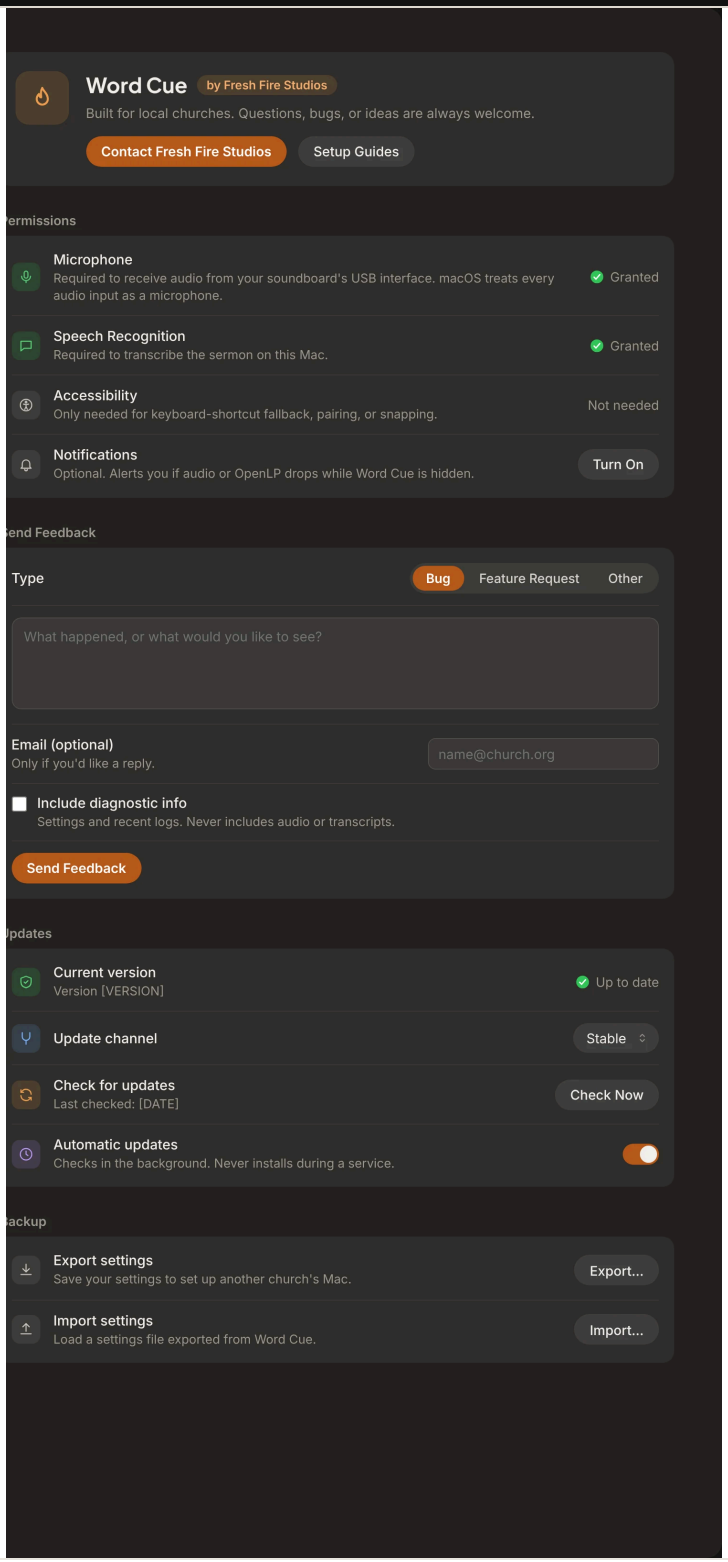


Figure 20 — Support.

- **Permissions** — live status of Microphone, Speech Recognition, Accessibility and Notifications (details in section 10).

- **Send Feedback** — Bug, Feature Request or Other, an optional email for a reply, and an optional "Include diagnostic info" box (settings and recent logs, never audio or transcripts).
- **Updates** — current version, Stable or Beta channel, Check Now, and automatic updates that never install during a service.
- **Backup** — Export settings to set up another church's Mac; Import a settings file.

Settings search

Type in the search box at the top of the sidebar to find any setting by name. Results show the setting and the section it lives in.

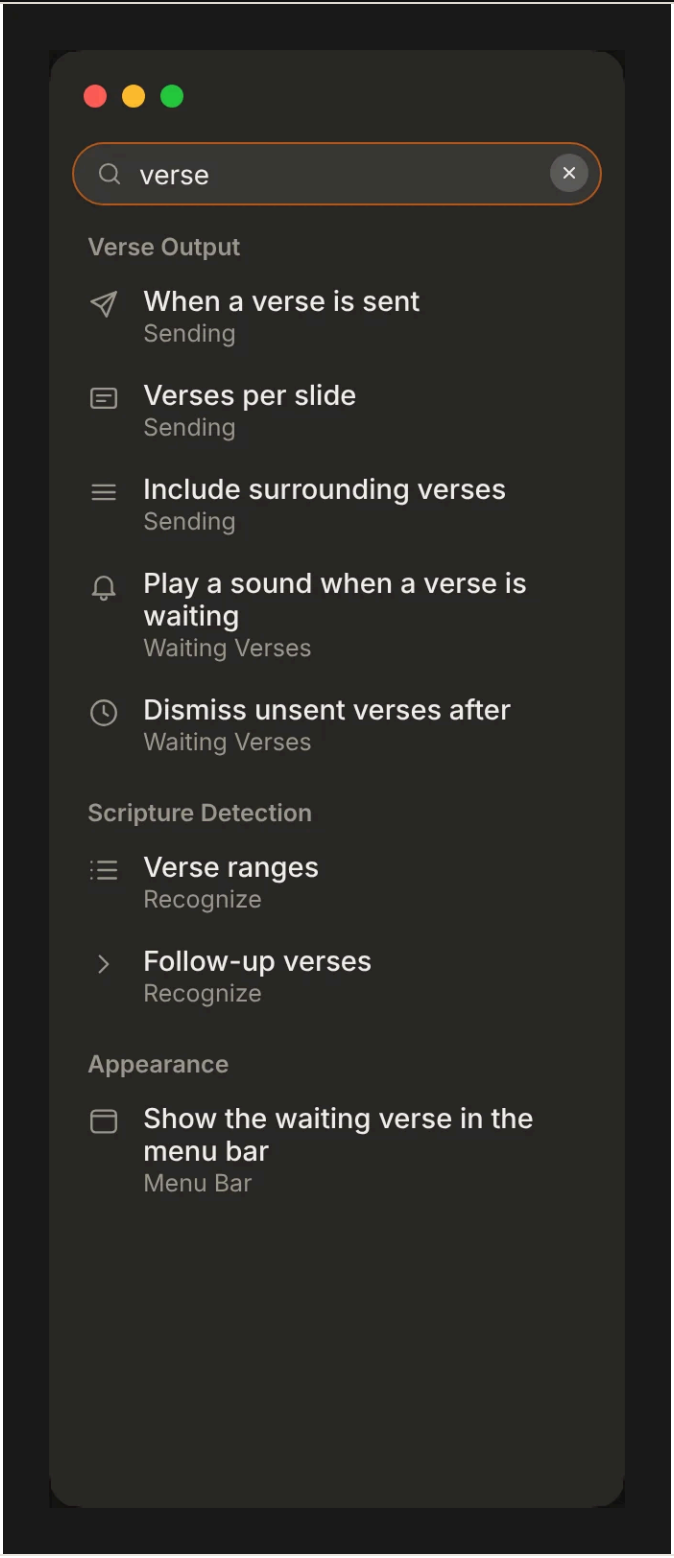


Figure 21 — Search results for settings.

08 Keyboard Shortcuts

Word Cue has two sets of keys. Plain keys work while Word Cue is in front. "Anywhere" keys add ^⌥ so they work while OpenLP is in front without interfering with typing in OpenLP. Keys are shown in light gray inside the button they trigger, like Mac menu shortcuts.

Action	In Word Cue	Anywhere
Send	↩	^⌥↩
Skip	esc	^⌥⌫
Pause or resume listening	space	^⌥Space
Clear screen	⌘B	^⌥B
Resend last verse	⌘R	^⌥R
Switch compact / full	⌘\	—
Show or hide Word Cue	—	⌥⌘W
Undo a file drop	⌘Z	—

All keys can be changed in Settings › Shortcuts & Controls, and Reset to Defaults restores them. "Shortcuts work while OpenLP is in front" turns the Anywhere set on or off.

09 Troubleshooting

When something goes wrong mid-service, Word Cue shows a red banner with a one-click fix and keeps working on everything it still can.

Problem	What you see	What to do
OpenLP lost connection	Red banner, red × next to OpenLP, Send and Skip dimmed. Word Cue keeps listening	Press Reconnect. If it fails, check OpenLP is open and Remote is on in its settings, then Test Connection in Verse Output
No audio from the interface	Red "No audio" pill and banner	Check the USB cable and that the pulpit channel is up on the board. Audio Settings opens the input page
Verses aren't being caught	Listening, but no Likely Matches	Check the live level in Audio Input; add names to Custom vocabulary; lower Minimum confidence slightly; turn on Debug logging
Wrong verses appear	Everyday phrases turning into verses	Add the phrase to Ignored phrases; keep Require a chapter number on; raise Minimum confidence
Same verse keeps reappearing	Repeats within a minute	Raise Duplicate cooldown in Filters
Audio drops out on a busy Mac	Gaps in detection	Set Buffer size to More stable in Advanced
Keys type into OpenLP	A plain key reaches OpenLP	Use the ^⌥ Anywhere keys while OpenLP is in front

TIP · Turn on Notifications in Support › Permissions so you are alerted if audio or OpenLP drops while Word Cue is hidden behind the compact panel or another app.

For anything else, send a report from Support › Send Feedback with "Include diagnostic info" checked. It sends settings and recent logs only, never audio or transcripts.

10 Privacy and Permissions

Audio never leaves the booth Mac. Transcription and detection run on-device, audio is never recorded or saved, and Word Cue works with no internet connection at all.

WHY · Missionaries and ministers sometimes share sensitive things from the pulpit. Word Cue is built so none of it can leave the building. It uses Apple's on-device models only and will never use AI models from unverified or untrusted sources.

Permissions

Permission	When asked	Why
Microphone	Always, at setup	Receive audio from the soundboard's USB interface. macOS treats every audio input as a microphone
Speech Recognition	Always, at setup	Transcribe the sermon on this Mac
Accessibility	Only if needed	Keyboard-shortcut fallback, pairing without stealing focus, and snapping OpenLP
Notifications	Optional	Alerts if audio or OpenLP drops while Word Cue is hidden

What is kept, and for how long

Data	Kept	Where
Audio	Never	Not recorded
Transcripts	7 days by default (this service only, 30 days, or don't keep)	This Mac

Service history	Verses cued in past services	This Mac
Settings	Until changed; exportable as a file	This Mac
Diagnostics	Only when you export or send them; never audio or transcripts	Sent only by you

11 Technical Specifications

Feature	Detail
Platform	macOS 27 or later — native SwiftUI application, Mac only
Hardware	Apple silicon required. RAM and storage minimums will be set by what the app actually needs and published before release
Interface	Native macOS controls and system materials; SF Pro for interface text, Plus Jakarta Sans for the Word Cue wordmark
Audio input	Any USB or Thunderbolt audio interface macOS recognizes, read through AVAudioEngine, with channel selection
Speech engine	Apple's on-device Speech framework; Enhanced mode on Apple Intelligence Macs. Fully offline
Detection	Apple's on-device Foundation Model plus a reference parser, confidence scoring, filters and cooldown
Bible text	KJV bundled (public domain); KJV is the default
Presentation app	OpenLP on the same Mac, through its remote API (port 4316) with automatic keyboard-shortcut fallback. Output is a swappable adapter so other apps can be added
Updates	Sparkle, cryptographically signed. Never installs during a service
Settings	Stored locally; export and import as a file
Data privacy	No audio or transcripts ever transmitted
Internet required	Never during services

12 Pricing and Distribution

PRICE · Free. No purchase, no subscription, no per-seat cost. An optional donation supports development.

Word Cue is open source and is distributed directly from the Fresh Fire Studios website as a signed and notarized macOS app, so macOS installs it without security warnings. It is not on the Mac App Store: the App Store sandbox conflicts with soundboard audio capture, local network access and Accessibility-based automation, which Word Cue needs.

Feature	Detail
Price	Free, with an optional donation
License	Open source (Apache 2.0 planned)
Distribution	Direct download from the Fresh Fire Studios website — Apple-notarized through the Developer ID program
Updates	Free and automatic via Sparkle; Stable or Beta channel
Seats	Install on as many church Macs as needed; export settings to copy a setup
Support	Contact and in-app feedback through Support

WHY · The goal is missional, not financial: any church can use Word Cue freely, and other platforms are welcome to build on the work if it genuinely helps churches.

13 Roadmap

Version 1 is the Mac app paired with OpenLP. These come after it.

Planned

Item	What it adds
iPhone and iPad companion	Scan a printed bulletin or handwritten outline with the camera, import a PDF, or dictate a verse list, and send it to the Mac over the local network. Also lets someone advance or reject verses from their phone instead of sitting at the booth
More presentation apps	Output adapters for FreeShow, ProPresenter, EasyWorship and Proclaim, using each app's API where one exists and keyboard automation where it doesn't
Service Log export	A full record of every verse in a service, exportable after the service for the pastor and congregation